

INTERVIEW | SHINZO ABE

“We’ll assess the deal’s impact on disarmament”

In an exclusive interview to INDIA TODAY, Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe speaks his mind on the future of Indo-Japanese relationship, while being non-committal on its support to the Indo-US nuke deal. Excerpts.

Q. Where do you see India and Japan in the international arena five years from now. What is the future of the relationship?

A. I believe Japan-India relations have a huge potential. Our areas of common interests are expanding such as maritime security, anti-terrorism measures and UN reforms. We have agreed to establish a Strategic and Global Partnership and I intend to take leadership in transforming our bilateral relationship. We would like to join hands on various fields such as politics, security, economy, people-to-people exchanges, academic exchanges and science technology.

Q. India and the US are in the midst of a nuclear deal. Will you extend civilian nuclear cooperation to India?

A. Japan is the only nation to have suffered atomic bombings. We have been making efforts towards elimination of nuclear weapons. Japan understands that India needs to meet its growing energy demands. However, on international civil nuclear cooperation with India—a state not party to the NPT—Japan has to consider various factors, including the effects on international nuclear disarmament and non-proliferation regimes. Japan will thoroughly study the recently released agreement, paying attention to the negotiation on safeguards between India and IAEA.

Q. You were the pioneer of the quadrilateral initiative among India, Japan, the US and Australia. Do you think it can act as a balancing force?

A. There is no intention to act as a ‘balancer’ towards a third country. We share values such as freedom, democracy, basic human rights and rule of law, and our aim is to promote regional cooperation for stability and prosperity under the principle of democracy and market economies.

Q. Climate change will be a key issue on your summit agenda and in the G-8 summit you host next year. What do you want India to do?

A. I proposed an initiative called “Cool Earth 50” which seeks to cut global greenhouse gas emissions by half by 2050. I am seeking India’s co-operation on this issue.

Q. Indo-Japanese economic ties have been moving at a snail’s pace. Which are the areas where we need to clear the hiccups?

A. It is true Japan and India have not fully explored each other’s economic potential. However, trade between the two countries in 2006 increased by almost 30 per cent to \$8.5 billion (Rs 34,587 crore) and Japan’s direct investment to India doubled to \$520 million (Rs 2,115 crore) in 2006. India and Japan have hidden possibilities and we are working on that.



said, “We have to consider the effects of the nuke deal on international nuclear disarmament and non-proliferation regimes.” Even the joint statement said they will have constructive deliberations on the issue. While Japanese companies like Toshiba—which has acquired Westinghouse—and Mitsubishi, are keen to supply nuclear reactors to India, Abe played it safe given the sensitivity of the nuclear issue in Japan.

Though both the countries maintain that the quadrilateral initiative including the US, India, Japan and Australia, is not aimed at countering China, it was apparent during the discussions that they have similar concerns on Beijing. Abe said he realised that India and Japan had a shared stake in the stability and prosperity of Asia, and also in some way had common threats from terrorism and proliferation of weapons of mass destruction. The two countries also have a shared interest in securing the sea lanes and in curbing sea piracy.

The other big gain of the visit was their declaration to accelerate the economic relationship, with the two leaders setting a target of \$20 billion (Rs 81,380 crore) for bilateral trade by 2010, even though Tokyo demanded a simpler tax regime and a hassle-free clearance in doing business in India. But the mood is upbeat following the visit, “The sake (Japanese alcoholic drink) is warming up, the visit has been hugely successful,” said Yasukuni Enoki, Japan’s envoy to India.

Some minor differences though did surface during the talks. “Some Indian officials have suggested that GE diesel engines would be a good option but we want eco-friendly electric locomotives,” said a diplomatic source. Delhi patiently heard Abe’s proposals to cut global emission of greenhouse gases by 50 per cent by the year 2050. But Manmohan said the matter needed to be discussed at the UN.

While the Japanese prime minister’s visit did not yield any big agreements, there is already enough on the plate for the two sides to implement. “A strong India is in the best interest of Japan, and a strong Japan is in the best interest of India,” Abe told Manmohan and his visit has set out the road map towards this goal. ■